

4, A Feudalized China Would Possess a Massive Military Advantage Over Surrounding Regions

Having explained the three aforementioned aspects, some might still harbor doubts, arguing: although the elite armed forces of **feudal lords**, centered around knights, possess extraordinary combat effectiveness, the direct demesnes (直辖领地) of lords in a **feudalized** society are ultimately limited. Meanwhile, along the incredibly long borderlines of China's massive territory, conquerors capable of mobilizing six-figure armies constantly emerge. Could the **feudal system** truly withstand such formidable martial power?

My answer consists of two points.

First, you inherently cannot demand a feudal society to solve problems that only a bureaucratic society is forced to face.

This is exactly what I stated previously: what the Chinese are most adept at is *solving problems that no one else has (which, in reality, means surface-level mitigation while fundamentally solving absolutely nothing)*.

Take the numerous conquerors the Chinese border has faced since the bureaucratic restoration. They were not supermen. Aside from Wanyan Aguda (完颜阿骨打), whose rise was indeed exceptionally rapid, it inherently required time for these conquerors to develop their regimes to the point of posing a significant threat to the Chinese Empire.

Piluoge (皮罗阁) did not unify the Six Zhao in a single day; Lê Lợi could not liberate Vietnam overnight; the Khitans coexisted with the Tang Dynasty for over two centuries; the Tanguts (党项人) served as the Dingnan Jiedushi for 150 years; Nurhaci had only 13 suits of armor when he initiated his uprising; and even Genghis Khan took 15 years to unify Mongolia.

An indisputable fact is that the reason the frontier situation of the Chinese Empire frequently deteriorated to an irremediable state was, in itself, the direct result of the **bureaucratic state** lacking response capabilities or simply "playing dead" (装死).

If the empire could genuinely mount effective responses, how much opportunity would these ethnic minority conquerors really have to snowball their power? That is highly questionable.

The superiority of the **feudal system** lies precisely in the fact that, when potential crises emerge on the borders, the **feudal lords** on the frontier would respond far more decisively and effectively than the circulating officials (*Liuguan* / 流官) of the court. This means that the massive barbarian armies the bureaucratic empire faced might never even appear on the borders of a feudal empire—**because they would likely have been strangled in the cradle long before.**

Second, you cannot assume that if China had genuinely embarked on the path of feudalization, it would forever remain in an early, immature state.

What ethnic minority conquerors would face would not be mere frontier warlords possessing only elements of **feudalization** (or those who couldn't even be called genuine **feudal lords**). Instead, they would face massive feudal kingdoms—much like England and France in Europe—possessing tens of thousands of knights serving as retainers.

China's **feudalization** process began the earliest in the entire world. If it had been able to proceed normally, it would have easily reached the level of the High Middle Ages by at least 1000 AD. By this stage, the organizational and mobilization capabilities of a feudal state's army could absolutely

not be considered inferior to those of a **restoration-bureaucratic state**; in terms of combat effectiveness, there would be a qualitative leap.

It is precisely because China, in reality, embarked on an aberrant path (邪路) that people find it exceedingly difficult to imagine just how terrifyingly powerful a **feudalized** medieval China would be.

Our country's current territorial area is roughly equivalent to Europe, and historically, the population of **Handi** (China Proper / 汉地) alone was slightly larger than Europe's. This means that a fully **feudalized** China in the High Middle Ages—even counting only the territory within the Great Wall—would be a cultural community covering 4 million square kilometers with a population of hundreds of millions.

Estimating based on Japan, which has a similar agricultural **production mode** to China, this implies that China may possess millions of feudal samurai/warriors (上百万的封建武士) in the Late Middle Ages, and China's military equipment would be even more highly sophisticated than in **our timeline** (本位面).

During the Northern and Southern Dynasties—the early phase of **feudalization**—massive numbers of cataphracts (具装骑兵 / heavily armored cavalry) had already appeared in northern China. If **feudalization** had proceeded normally for another five centuries, what its armaments would have evolved into is simply beyond imagination!

Even if China were not in a unified state due to the **feudalization** process, judging from the geopolitical situation of China's interior, there would be, at most, five or six major regimes. Yet, the average population of *each* of these regimes would already be equivalent to ten times that of Mongolia when Genghis Khan just unified it.

Facing such a colossal China—bristling with castles, wielding millions of warriors, and armed to the teeth—even ten Genghis Khans would be left helplessly staring in despair.

The fact is, if China were truly **feudalized**, the Chinese vassals would absolutely not be squatting behind the Great Wall or along the coastlines doing nothing; they would have expanded the borders outward long ago!

Judging from the actual historical trajectories of Eastern Europe and Central Asia converting to Orthodoxy and Islam respectively, by the second half of the 12th century when Genghis Khan was born, the Mongolian region at the eastern end of the Eurasian Steppe would have long since adopted the same religion as the Chinese interior. (*If China were feudalized, it would most likely adopt a religion suited to the requirements of the feudalization period; historically speaking, this should have been Buddhism*).

The nomads of the Mongolian region would highly likely be widely welcomed as mercenaries for the Chinese vassals. However, the astronomical chasm in scale between them and China would make it utterly impossible for them to achieve a successful **Ru Guan** (Entering the Pass / 入关) like the nomadic tribes near the Middle East.

Therefore, assuming China's **feudalization** continued normally, pondering whether China could defend against foreign invasions is fundamentally a meaningless question. Pondering *to what extent it could expand* is the only genuinely meaningful alternative history (架空) thought experiment.

The reason people today doubt a **feudalized** China's ability to cope with border threats is, in essence, because China historically never achieved a mature **feudal society**. The **bureaucratic state** would only permit certain feudal elements to emerge for self-preservation when it consciously sensed impending doom; once its objective was achieved, it would immediately snuff them out. Under these conditions, the **feudal society** could never possibly reach maturity.

That the **feudal society** could not develop fully under the **bureaucratic state** is the crime of the **bureaucratic state**, not the fault of the former.

Therefore, when we see the Nine Dukes of the Jin Dynasty (金朝的九公) swept away like dead leaves by the Mongols, or massive numbers of late Ming warlords surrendering to the Manchus, we must point out that **the true entity responsible for these debacles is the court itself!**

Since the despotic court never allowed the **feudal landlord class** to openly and honorably participate in political affairs as rulers, enjoy economic privileges, and bear military obligations, it should not expect regional warlords and landlord militias to miraculously rally to save the throne (勤王保驾) when imminent disaster strikes.

Nowhere in the world is there such a one-sidedly advantageous deal! (天下从来没有这么占尽便宜的事!)

4, 封建化的中国将对周边地区具有巨大的武力优势

说明完三个方面,或许还是会有人怀疑说,封建领主以骑士为核心的精锐武装虽然战斗力过人,但是在封建化社会领主的直辖领地毕竟有限,而中国庞大领土的漫长边境线四周总是会出现能够拥兵六位数的征服者,封建体制真的能够抵抗如此强大的武力吗?我的回答是两点,首先是你原本也不能够要求一个封建社会去解决官僚社会才不得不面临的问题。这就是我之前所说的,中国人最擅长解决的就是别人没有的问题(实际上也就是表面缓和,根本一个也解决不了)。就拿中国在官僚复辟以来边境所面临的这么多征服者们来说,他们又不是什么超人,除了完颜阿骨打确实崛起得过快以外,这些征服者们要让自己的政权能够发展到对中华帝国产生显著威胁本身就需要时间。皮罗阁不是一日就统一了六诏,黎利也不能一天就解放越南,契丹和唐朝共存了两个多世纪,党项人曾经做了一百五十年的定难军,努尔哈赤起兵时只有十三副铠甲,即使是成吉思汗,统一蒙古也花了十五年。一个不争的事实就是,中华帝国的边境形势之所以经常会发生到不可收拾的地步,本身就是官僚国家缺乏应对或者干脆装死的结果,如果帝国真的能做出有效回应的话,这些少数民族征服者能有多少机会像滚雪球一样的壮大就成了一个大问题。而封建体制的优越性就在于边境的封建领主至少比朝廷的流官在边境出现潜在危机时进行更为果断有效的处置,这就意味着官僚帝国所面临的蛮族大军未必会出现在封建帝国的边境线上,因为它可能早就被扼杀了。

其次是你不能假定中国如果真的走上了封建化道路它永远停留在那种早期的,不成熟的状态。少数民族征服者面临的就不会是仅仅存在封建化因素甚至称不上封建领主的藩镇,而是像欧洲英国法国那样大国有成千上万的骑士作为扈从的封建王国。中国的封建化进程在全世界范围内开始最早,如果能够正常进行下去,至少在公元1000年的时候也能够进入中世纪盛期的水平,到这个阶段封建国家的军队组织能力和动员能力就已经完全不能认为比复辟官僚国家差了,在战斗力上更有质的差别。正是因为中国在现实里走上了一条邪路,所以人们很难想象一个封建化的中世纪中国会有何等强大的威力。我国现在的领土面积与欧洲相当,在历史时期即使是汉地的人口也要略多于欧洲。这意味着一个完全封建化的中世纪盛期中国即使只计算长城以内的领土也是一个有400万平方公里面积,人口上亿的文化共同体。按照农业生产方式与中国相近的日本来估算,这意味着中国在中世纪晚期可能会有上百万的封建武士,而中国的军事装备甚至还要比本位面更加精良。中国在封建化初期的南北朝时期北方就已经出现了大量具装骑兵,如果封建化正常继续进行五个世纪军备会变成什么样子根本难以想象。

就算因为封建化进程中国不处于统一的状态,但是从我国内地的地缘形势来看充其量也就存在五六个主要政权,就这平均每个政权的人口就已经相当于十个成吉思汗刚刚统一的蒙古。面对如此庞大的,

城堡林立的，有上百万武士的，武装到牙齿的中国，十个成吉思汗来了也得干瞪眼。事实就是，如果真封建化了中国的诸侯根本不可能蹲在长城边上或者海岸线上不动，他们早就把边界扩张出去了。从东欧和中亚分别皈依东正教和伊斯兰教的实际情况来看，到成吉思汗出生的公元 12 世纪后半叶，欧亚大草原东头的蒙古地区早就已经跟中国内地信仰同一个宗教了（中国如果封建化大概率当然也会信仰一种符合封建化时期要求的宗教，从历史上看应该是佛教）。蒙古地区的游牧民大概率会作为中国诸侯的雇佣兵而受到广泛欢迎，但是与中国体量天渊之别的差距让他们压根没可能像中东附近的游牧民族一样入关成功。因此假设中国封建化正常继续下去，考虑中国能不能防御外敌侵略根本就是一个没有意义的问题，考虑他到底能扩张到什么程度才是真正有意义的架空。今天的人们之所以会怀疑封建化的中国难以应对边疆的威胁，本质是因为中国历史上从来也没有达到过成熟的封建社会，官僚国家只有在自觉大事不妙的时候才会允许一些封建因素出现以图自保，一旦达到目的又会马上将其掐灭。在这种条件下，封建社会就永远不可能走向成熟。封建社会无法在官僚国家进行充分的发展，这是官僚国家的罪行而不是前者的，因此当我们看到金朝的九公被蒙古摧枯拉朽地击溃，明末的军阀大批投降满清，就必须指出真正需要为这些事情负责的是朝廷本身。专制朝廷既然从来不允许封建地主阶级以统治者的身份光明正大地参与政治事务，享有经济特权并承担军事义务，那它就不要指望大祸临头的时候各地的军阀地主武装能够勤王保驾，天下从来没有这么占尽便宜的事。